

Cold Email System — How It Works

The full process, start to finish, in plain terms — and what's built vs not. Updated 2026-06-27.

🔒 Safety: the whole system is built and tested but sits behind a master OFF switch (DRY-RUN). **Nothing has been emailed to anyone.** It only sends when we deliberately flip the switch.

● Built & working ● Partly built ● Not built yet ● Built but locked (off)



1 • Lead pool

Every business owner we might contact — **187,000 ready to use** (405,000 total), cleaned and de-duplicated from our old lists. Now kept in a secure cloud database (Neon), off anyone's laptop, and searchable.

BUILT



2 • Qualification — who do we contact, and under which brand?

A funnel that runs cheap checks first and only spends money on the leads that survive. This decides eligibility + routes each lead to Franchise Sellers or Company Sellers. Now wired end-to-end and verified on real leads.

BUILT

Stage 0 • Free filters

Drop anyone clearly outside the US, or outside a campaign's target area. Costs nothing.

Built

Stage 1 • Company lookup

Looks up company size, age & industry (LeadMagic). The size (≤50 staff) and age (≥3 yrs) cutoffs now run automatically, and only drop a lead when the data is certain.
Tested on 1,000 leads: found 93%, with staff count on 85% and founding year on 70%.

Built

Stage 2 • AI check

AI reads the web + LinkedIn to confirm: is this the **current** owner (not retired/sold)? US-based? Franchise or private? Not private-equity/public. Also estimates a revenue band. The most important step.

Built

Stage 3 • Revenue/size limits

No tool reliably has revenue or franchise-unit counts for tiny private firms, so by design these are **soft signals, not hard blocks**: staff count is the revenue proxy, the AI flags likely-too-big ones for review.

Built (soft)



3 • Email check

Confirm each email address is real and won't bounce (MillionVerifier — cheap and accurate). Risky addresses are dropped so we protect our sending reputation.

BUILT



4 • Do-not-contact filter

Never email anyone on the do-not-contact list, anyone already in our CRM, or anyone in a recent-contact cooldown. Three safety layers so we never double-touch or bother the wrong person.

BUILT



5 • Write the email

Build a personalized email from approved templates — wording is varied so each one is unique, and we never fake personalization. Every email automatically gets the legally-required footer (our mailing address + an opt-out line).

BUILT



6 • Pre-send safety gate

A final checklist before anything goes out: bounce rate low, sending domains healthy (SPF/DMARC pass), tracking off, address + opt-out present, copy approved. It also forces cold email to come only from our "lookalike" domains — **never our main domain or staff inboxes.**

BUILT



7 • Send the emails

Send through Instantly, slowly and spaced out, from our approved "**lookalike**" **sending domains only**. Your real franchisesellers.com / companysellers.com inboxes are in Instantly purely to stay warm and are **hard-blocked from cold sending** — the system refuses to launch a campaign that includes them. Held behind the master OFF switch — **nothing actually sends until we flip it on a small test batch.**

BUILT · LOCKED



8 • Read the replies

When someone replies, AI sorts it into 11 types — interested, not right now, wrong person, unsubscribe, "I'm a buyer," and so on — so each gets the right follow-up.

BUILT



9 • Route to the right place

PARTIAL

Interested sellers go to the correct CRM (Franchise or Company Sellers); buyers go to Yvonne; unsubscribes go to do-not-contact. The sorting + routing logic is built; the automatic "catch live replies" connector still needs wiring.

ALWAYS-ON SUPPORT SYSTEMS

🗄️ Database (Neon) • Built

Cloud Postgres holding the whole pool + every result, now incl. each company's looked-up size/age. Cheap, backed up, run by Claude.

🔔 Health monitor • Built

Daily check of 32 domains + 91 inboxes (DNS, blacklist, warmup). Emails Theodore **only** if something breaks.

📊 Operator dashboard • Built

Malcolm's control panel at /marketing — **redesigned** with Email Marketing + Google Ads tabs, light/dark mode, and a step-by-step email workflow.

📁 Operator skills • Built

Guided workflows: campaign strategy, self-improving copywriting, weekly lead-pull.

NOT BUILT YET / NEEDS YOUR GO

- **Run qualification at scale** — the full funnel now runs end-to-end and is verified on real leads. A larger paid pass (~\$13–30 per 1,000, now incl. the company lookup) builds the real qualified list. *Pending your go on the scope.*
- **First live send** — flip the master switch on one small, qualified, freshly-verified batch and watch it. *Pending your go.*
- **Refine the ideal-customer profile (ICP)** — a short fillable form for Eric is ready. *Pending: send it to Eric.*
- **Connect Google Ads live data** — the dashboard tab is ready; it needs your Google Ads API credentials to go live.
- **Later:** auto-catch live replies (webhook), Instantly block-list sync, a "launch" button on the dashboard, and reverse lead magnets (Malcolm + Triston).

Cold Email System process map · built & verified in DRY-RUN · nothing sends until the master switch is deliberately flipped on a small test batch.